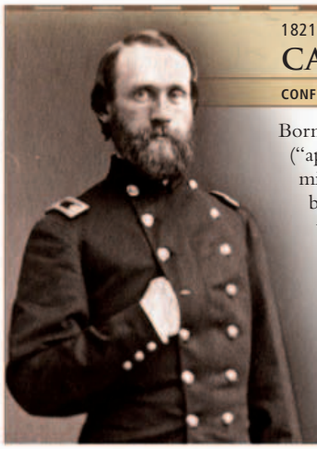


1821–1877

## CATESBY AP JONES

**CONFEDERATE NAVY LIEUTENANT**

Born in Fairfield, Virginia, Catesby ap Roger Jones ("ap" meaning "son of" in Welsh) was appointed midshipman in 1836 and served extensively at sea, becoming a lieutenant in 1849. In the 1850s he was involved in the development of naval weapons, and served as an ordnance officer aboard *Merrimack* when she began service in 1856. He became a Confederate Navy Lieutenant in 1861, and converted *Merrimack* into the ironclad *Virginia*, taking temporary command of her at the battle of Hampton Roads. He was killed in 1877 in a feud between his and another man's children.

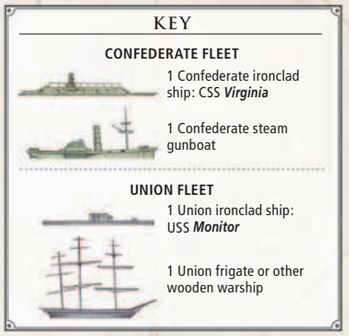
night of March 8–9. She was a semi-submerged armored raft designed by Swedish engineer John Ericsson, driven by Ericsson's novel marine screw, and topped by a revolving iron gun turret containing two 11 in smoothbore Dahlgren guns. The latter had reinforcing muzzle swells that permitted large amounts of explosives to be used without fear of the guns exploding (and gave them a soda-bottle shape), the pair aboard *Monitor* being of a higher caliber than the two aboard *Virginia*. Unlike her opponent, which was simply a wooden ship dressed in iron, *Monitor* was the first truly semi-submersible warship, having all of her features underwater save for the turret and a tiny pilothouse up front.

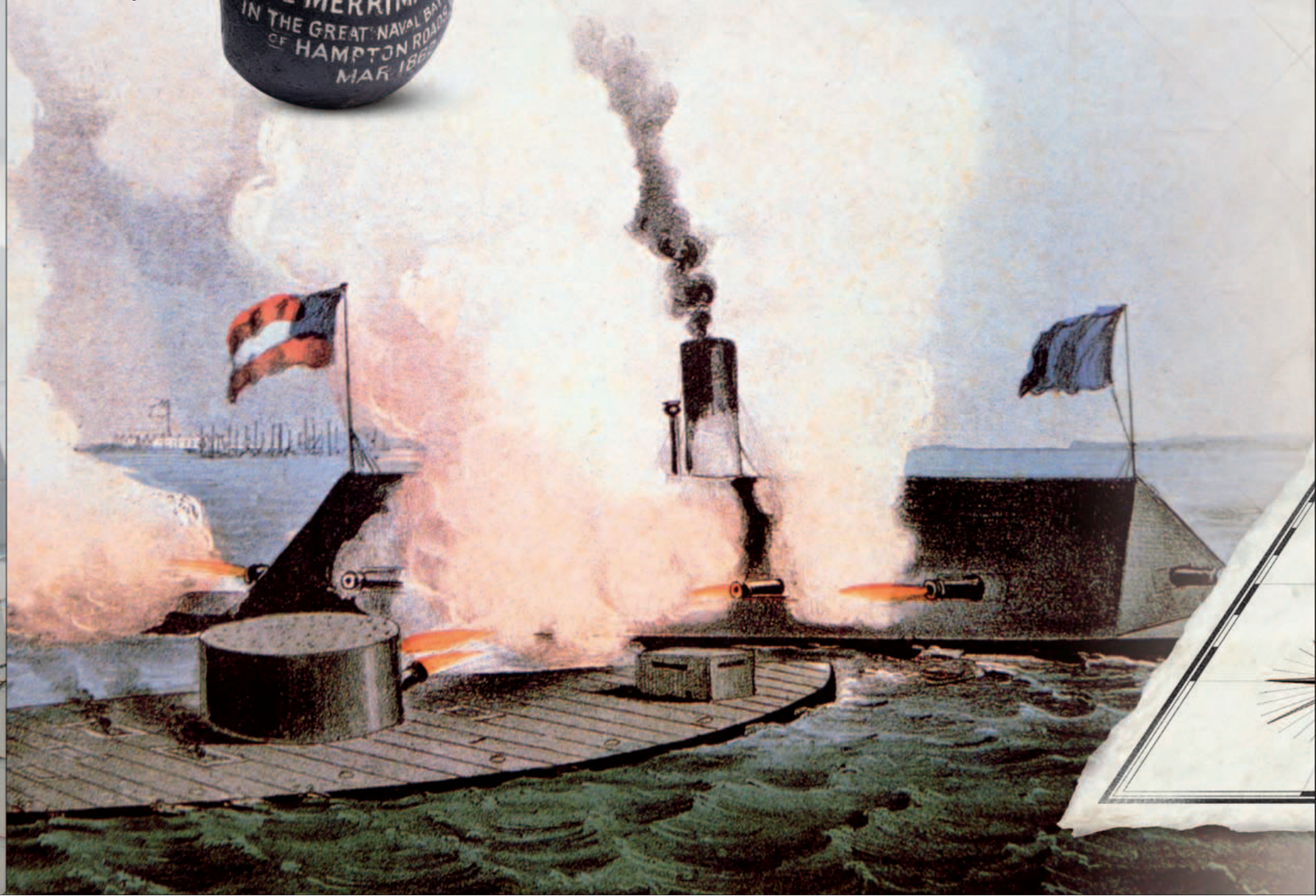



**Flattened shot**
One of the shots fired at *Virginia* by *Monitor* flattened on impact with the former's thick armor—*Merrimac* being the Union name for the *Virginia*.

The duel that followed the next day, when *Virginia* steamed out and found *Monitor* defending *Minnesota*, may rank as the oddest in naval history. For four hours the two ships blasted at one another at close range, producing little more than dents in their iron armor. Visibility was poor for commanders and gunners on both ships. *Monitor* suffered problems with its turret, which had to be kept permanently rotating, firing as it turned. *Virginia* had the disadvantage of a V-shaped hull (*Monitor* was flat-bottomed) and at one point ran aground, refloating with a supreme effort of her overstretched engines. Ramming proved as ineffectual as gunfire. A shell exploded on the eye-slit of *Monitor*'s cramped pilothouse, and its captain, John L. Worden, was burned in the face and blinded. But his first officer, Samuel D. Green, continued the fight, and in the afternoon *Virginia* withdrew to port.

Over the following two months *Virginia* made occasional sorties into Hampton Roads, but the epic duel was not repeated. Both sides claimed victory, but with the blockade still intact, the strategic balance remained in the Union's favor. When he heard of the engagement, *Monitor*'s designer John Ericsson criticized the crew for firing only solid shot at *Virginia*'s upper works, claiming that firing explosive shells beneath the waterline would have sunk the Confederate ship. Nevertheless, neither ironclad survived the year. *Virginia* was scuttled by her commander in May 1861 when the course of the land battle forced the Confederates to abandon Portsmouth. *Monitor*, which was never truly seaworthy, sank on December 31 while under tow in an Atlantic gale.



**Duel in Hampton Roads**
*Virginia* (right) fires its 7 in stern and casement guns, while *Monitor* fires its 11-in turret equivalents. *Virginia*'s use of molten shot enhanced the need for ships to be made of iron.